The other disappointment in this match was that VVS Laxman, then a youngster, fractured his finger and was faced with having to go back to India. Distressed, Laxman was sitting in one corner of the dressing room in tears. I tried to console him, saying that injuries happen, but that he shouldn't worry too much about them as he had a long career ahead of him. In hindsight it was a prophetic statement!

India in the West Indies, March–April 1997

India had not won a series in the Caribbean since 1971 and I looked on this tour as a major opportunity to leave the disappointment of South Africa behind. The conditions were different again from those in South Africa, and we needed to adjust quickly. However, our preparations suffered a serious jolt when Srinath, our leading fast bowler, was ruled out of the tour because he needed shoulder surgery. Abey Kuruvilla, a tall fast-medium bowler from Mumbai, performed admirably as his replacement, but the situation illustrates a very serious problem I faced in South Africa and subsequently in the Caribbean.

On tours like that, I believed we really needed three quality fast bowlers but unfortunately I never had more than two. In South Africa, Abey Kuruvilla was not even part of the squad. Even when I was desperate to have him, the selectors refused to include him. After making his Ranji Trophy debut in 1991, Abey had played five seasons of first-class cricket by then and would have been a handy bowler in South Africa. As it was, after good opening spells from both Srinath and Prasad, we failed to sustain the momentum. In the West Indies, we would once again rue the absence of a quality third seamer.

Despite losing Srinath, we played well enough in the first two Tests in March 1997, at Sabina Park and Port-of-Spain. Both matches ended in hard-fought draws and for once it seemed that we had managed to adjust to the conditions, with our batting looking solid against the West Indian pace quartet of Curtly Ambrose, Mervyn Dillon, Ian Bishop and Franklyn Rose. By the time we went to Barbados for the third match of the five-Test series on 27 March, I was feeling confident that we could do something special.

We started well at the Kensington Oval and managed to bowl out the West Indians for under 300, thanks to some fine bowling from Venkatesh Prasad, with 5–82, and despite a Shivnarine Chanderpaul century. As I